

STRATEGIC PLAN

2023-25



Grove Community
HOUSING ASSOCIATION



**Working together
to shape our
community's future**



CONTENTS



4

STRATEGIC STATEMENT



5

WHO WE ARE



7

OUR VALUES



8

HOW WE WORK
TOGETHER



9

WHAT WE HAVE
ACHIEVED TOGETHER



14

SWOT ANALYSIS



17

OUR SEVEN
STRATEGIC PILLARS



30

MEASURING SUCCESS



Grove Community
HOUSING ASSOCIATION

OUR MISSION

**“To provide quality homes and services
for our tenants and wider community”**



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Annual Review in a
different format (such as
larger print or different
language) please contact
our office.

JOINT STRATEGIC STATEMENT FROM CHAIR AND CEO

Presenting our collaboratively crafted Strategic Plan, co-created with our Board, tenants, and stakeholders, we do so with the intent of enhancing the lives of the community we serve. Safety, quality, sustainability and growth are pivotal aspects guiding our goals, reflecting our unwavering commitment to these non-negotiable areas.

While our goals are ambitious, they remain achievable in the right social and economic environment. We have updated our Strategic Plan as it is our role in serving our tenants to both assess and respond with agility to our changing operating environment. We have continued to build on the foundations of our previous Strategic Plan. Our focus for 2023 and 2024 is to ensure our staffing structure is fit for purpose and embedded into our organization and its values. We will measure this by our performance and tenant feedback and our contributions to sector wide engagement towards solutions.

As a small provider it is important that our voice is heard by all stakeholders. The announcement of the severe cuts to the Social Housing Development Programme coupled with the NI Water budgetary constraints and underfunding have a very real impact on our ability to deliver our new Passivhaus homes. Additionally, the construction sector response maintenance market is both reducing in competitive interest and rising in costs.

It is prudent to reassess our strategic ambitions and during the final quarters of 2024 Board and SMT will take time away to review the Association's position and develop a new Strategic Plan for 2025-28 that fully addresses the many challenges in our sector. We welcome the revitalization of the NIHE and will review any impacts and consider how we best contribute to to help in reducing the the social housing waiting list, which is now 49,000 and growing. We welcome the delay of the implementation of the new Procurement Act and guidance until February 2025. This also will impact on how we do things now and into the future.

However, despite this fast-paced challenging environment, as a strong and independent organization, with 47 years of accomplishments behind us, we are determined to contribute more to a growing and vibrant North Belfast. The Board,



endorsing the Strategic Plan, is dedicated to allocating appropriate resources to transform goals into tangible deliverables. As a small organization, achieving value in all our endeavours is crucial to our success.

Under the inspirational leadership of our Chief Executive, we are confident that with the expert support and strategic direction of the Board, staff will embrace any necessary change or ways of working. Together we will overcome the significant and very real challenges ahead to make a lasting difference for all in our community.

Our commitment to professionalism and accountability to a wide range of stakeholders goes beyond mere business targets. This Strategic Plan establishes standards and operational approaches, striking a balance between measurable outcomes and investments that showcase our dedication to fostering caring, strong communities. Good governance and accountability play a significant role in this plan.

Given our size and purpose, the document presents a blend of strategic growth and operational delivery. We make no apologies for this approach, as we believe it is the most effective way to ensure that our stated intentions translate into practical actions, ultimately making meaningful differences in our community.

Recognizing the strength derived from unity, we pay tribute to all those who support us. Looking ahead, we commit not only to investing in safe, secure and sustainable homes for all but also working in partnership and doing whatever it takes to support the communities we serve.

B. Dunn *A. Crawford*

Mr Brian Dunn
Chair

Ms Agnes Crawford
Chief Executive

WHO WE ARE

Established in 1977 amid the migration from North Belfast due to subpar housing and environmental conditions, Grove Community Housing Association (GCHA) has been instrumental in urban regeneration of the area. Through renovations and new construction projects, our small community-based organization has significantly improved the community, managing a stock of 215* (*Feb 2024) social housing units. These are allocated strictly through the Common Selection Scheme to those in most housing need.

Regulated by the Department for Communities (DfC) and the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA), and registered with the Charity Commission of Northern Ireland, Grove CHA has a proven track record in the regeneration of the Grove area. Future plans include expanding our housing portfolio and developing 31 new social housing homes at the former Grove School primary school site on North Queen Street, Belfast.

As an employer of a growing, dedicated team of nine staff, we also contribute to the economy through local construction and the service industry through contracts for development, maintenance works, IT services, accountancy, and insurance.

Oversight and strategic direction of our work are entrusted to the restructured voluntary Board of Management, whose diverse skills and experience benefit the Association greatly. Together with the staff at our York Road office, we share a common commitment to providing safe, good quality housing conditions for all tenants and improve the community and opportunities for better life outcomes.

Operating in a challenging environment marked by sectarian interfaces, deprivation,

and disadvantage, we navigate issues shared by all social housing providers, including skills shortages, rising costs of maintenance, capacity, demand and regulatory standards. Ongoing government underfunding of wider vital services adds to the complexity of challenges. The cost of living rises for households remains a significant concern and we remain committed to mitigate against these through provision of access to valuable advice services and ensuring value for money.

Against this challenging backdrop, our Strategic Plan has been crafted to align with our aspirations for growth. Through a skilled and enthusiastic Board and Staff team, we aim to provide excellent service while navigating the complexities of the evolving housing landscape.



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OUR VALUES



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Our values are central to all that we do and guide decision making, behaviours and the way in which we act collaboratively with partners within the community in which we work:



APPROACHABILITY

We continually consider the best way to provide access to our organisation in a way that is friendly and centred on the individual needs of everyone.

1

2

SERVICE FOCUSED

We strive to continually improve the beneficial impact for those who access our service range.



HONESTY & INTEGRITY

We do the right thing, in the right way, irrespective of the potential for adverse consequence.

3

4

ACCOUNTABILITY

We take ownership for our individual and collective actions with a willingness to change where that is the right thing to do.



COMPASSION

We approach all situations with human kindness and a willingness to help.

5

HOW WE WORK TOGETHER

Our strength and commitment to a shared purpose are evident in the collaborative and teamwork approach we adopt. We strive to cultivate a collaborative working style that optimises our combined talents in any given circumstances.



We attentively listen to others' perspectives, carefully weighing their views before making key decisions.



We dedicate ourselves to continual improvement and innovation, cultivating positive environments for collaborative creation that yield tangible results.



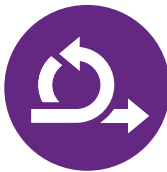
We adhere to ethical principles and take responsibility for our actions.



We afford equal consideration to everyone, ensuring that each individual feels valued for their contributions.



We embrace diversity, encourage teamwork, and wholeheartedly dedicate ourselves to a shared mission.



We exhibit flexibility, adaptability, and responsiveness, pivoting to provide support to all our stakeholders.

What We Have Achieved Together and Will Build On

Grove Community Housing Association is a bespoke charitable organisation nestled in the heart of inner City North Belfast. We're not just a Housing Association; we're a proud beacon of independence, deeply dedicated to serving our local community.

We have evidenced our commitment to successfully sustaining autonomy. This allows our focus to be laser-sharp on understanding both the needs of our tenants and delivering effective solutions to truly enrich and improve the lives of those around us. By keeping our operations close to home, we ensure key investment gives back to our community. Through effective use of our resources, timely stock condition surveys and investment we provide good quality housing for our 215* households (*Feb 2024).

We maintain affordable, responsible rents and provide access to benefits advice, resulting in very low levels of rental arrears and voids. This ensures maximisation of our income and provides healthy scope for future investment which provides a rock solid financial foundation. We ensure we can fulfil our commitments to our tenants, providing safe and good quality homes and wider community investment. Importantly, it ensures we play our part in tackling the housing crisis. This is achievable by having a good asset base for responsible borrowing for development opportunities for new and sustainable homes.

As a transformed Housing Association, (DfC) Regulatory Grade 1, and sector recognised award-winning Association, we're not content with just meeting expectations.



We're driven by the same energy of local people who came together in 1977 to find solutions to housing need and local issues. We have that same passion to tackle the housing crisis and transform neglected parts of our great City and surrounding areas. With both the Assembly re-established and as Belfast embarks on its most ambitious City-wide plans for investment and sustainability in decades, there couldn't be a more exciting time to launch our ambitious Strategic Plan. It sets out the active role we will play in both seeking and bringing investment for the area.

We commit to utilising that investment to deliver long lasting solutions to address a wide range of needs of those who call this place home, not just physical housing needs. We fully appreciate the value good quality sustainable housing has on health outcomes, particularly for our young people.

We take a measured approach to development, and when we do build, we strive to do so in the most sustainable way for the community, its residents and the environment we all live in. Take, for instance, our groundbreaking project at Loughview Terrace, which turned a neglected, contaminated and constrained vacant site into awardwinning, low energy stunning homes (Winners of the Regeneration Award of Royal Society of Ulster Architects Design Awards). Our long standing commitment to the environment, our dedication to sustainability and innovation also earned us recognition and certification as pioneers of the first retrofit “Active House” in Europe in 2012. This was before “retrofit” was a pressing issue as organisations begin to strive to tackle the sustainability challenges and lack of funding head on through their ESG strategies.

Within that context; it should come as no surprise that our ambitious Board and CEO have striven since 2019 to bring the unquestionable benefits of Passive housing standards to the attention of the wider NI social housing sector.

We have diligently pushed through significant external factors to obtain planning permission. We continue to strive to deliver Northern Ireland’s largest social housing Passivhaus development of homes. We appeal for adequate funding from the Social Housing Development Programme to deliver these much needed homes that will improve life, health and economic outcomes for the new residents.

This will repurpose the vacant former Grove Primary School site, where we are set to deliver these innovative, environmentally conscious homes for social housing rent to those in great need on the Common Selection Scheme waiting list.

This significant investment of over £6M not only revitalizes our local economy but also



enhances the quality of life and financial burdens of energy costs for 31 households. For a number of years, we have echoed that good health requires good housing and living conditions. The health and economic benefits of living in a Passivhaus, with clean filtered air and very comfortable living environments can be life changing for many, particularly those with respiratory conditions. We will also steadily grow our stock through individual purchases and also seek every opportunity to bring unused areas of land back into use for vibrant homes of the future.

We work collectively to appeal for adequate and multi-year retrofit funding for NI to bring us into parity with the rest of the UK. We recognise the need to do all in our power to bring existing homes up to a high performing energy rating, as households struggle with rising energy costs and to tackle climate goals to reduce carbon emissions.

Yet, our mission extends beyond bricks and mortar. We recognise our outward view is formed by the collective vision of our people. We aspire to be an attractive employer, offering support programmes, continued learning and development, family (yes pets are family too!) friendly policies, and sector benchmarked salaries. Investing in our staff not only drives our success but also fosters personal growth and positive, caring tenant



and community engagement. We take our professionalism seriously and commit to playing our role in striving to showcase the positive impacts it can achieve.

We remain committed to engage at all levels, from government officials to grass root community levels, to have appropriate and adequate environments, policy, legislation and funding for the sector to deliver. The housing sector demonstrated the significant and positive difference its investment brings to the NI economy.

We have supported the development of an engaged and active ‘Tenant Voice’ Group of tenants who help examine how we do things and truly help shape positive change to the services we deliver. We are indebted to their commitment, and truly enjoy our opportunities to meet, get to know one another and engage together to co-create solutions and opportunities to make a difference, big or small. We promote a wide range of opportunities for all to engage with us at a level they are comfortable with. We are excited as they embark on becoming a fully constituted group and maximise the opportunities this

will provide and realise their ambitions to deliver more in the community.

Collaboration, learning and innovation are at the core of everything we do. By partnering with training and education organizations like the NOW Group, CIH, NIFHA, Habitat for Humanity and Women’s TEC, we create opportunities for our people to shine, and demonstrate their unique talents and receive recognition. We develop and support initiatives like the ‘Grow with Grove’ placement, enriching lives and communities in the process. We are proud of our staff who go above and beyond for our tenants and communities, truly embracing both our values and the professional standards of the housing sector.

With a small but highly dedicated and experienced staff team we embrace new ways of working. We maximise opportunities to do things in the most efficient way, implementing technological solutions that provide assurance and added value. This frees up valuable time to focus on the areas that matter to our tenants and wide range of stakeholders. We are small enough to respond in an agile way to the ever changing environments, internal and external. We were recognised for our





work at the CIH All Ireland Housing Awards, winning “Innovation in Housing” Category in 2022. We were also shortlisted in 2023 for the “More than Bricks and Mortar” award category. For 2024 we are proud to also have our own “Housing Hero” and “Lifetime Achievement Award” shortlisted candidates and wish Paul Stuart and Erskine Holmes OBE success in their respective categories for their dedicated contributions.

Through our partnerships, we’ve become a hub for expert advice on benefits, finance, and employment, providing a lifeline to those in need. The impact of this work is immeasurable, echoing our shared commitment to making a tangible difference where it truly matters. We do this through provision of free office space and administrative services to enable North Belfast Advice Partnership to deliver weekly advice services. The outcomes of sound advice have been life changing for many. We also are grateful to the many organisations such as LCAP and ROC (NI) for their vital services such as social supermarkets, energy

vouchers, community resource events and school uniform and winter clothing appeals.

At Grove Community Housing Association, we’re not just building homes; we’re nurturing futures and transforming communities, one brick at a time. Through the lifetime of this Strategic Plan, we will reach the incredible milestone of fifty years of delivering lasting urban regeneration and sustaining and supporting communities where people can thrive and reach their full potential.

We can’t achieve this in isolation and continue to both strengthen existing strategic partnerships and reach out to others that share our visions and ambitions. Embark with us on this exciting journey, where passion meets purpose, and together, we’ll keep building back North Belfast, making it a vibrant and sought after place to call home.



SWOT ANALYSIS

The Board and staff team spent time examining how Grove operates within the wider economic/political environment. We collectively analysed all aspects of our service delivery, and incorporated tenant and stakeholder feedback into the assessment. Part of those focused discussions centred on a SWOT analysis, the outcome of which was influential in going through a longer-term process to shape objectives meaningful to its purpose. Our updated SWOT analysis is shown below. However, it is important to note that this is a dynamic set of strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats, and is not set in stone as we continually work and respond in an agile way as we pivot and move forward to provide for our tenants.

Strengths

- Locally based office with good local and tenant knowledge
- History and long serving recognition in the area
- Strong financial position
- Good performance across arrears management, voids control, planned maintenance, financial management and tenant satisfaction.
- Good audit assessments - both internal and external
- Grade 1 Regulatory Judgement
- Low anti-social behaviour within housing stock
- Dedicated staff team
- Active and involved Board – new Board Members filling skills gaps
- Development of new homes
- Staff wellbeing focus and competitive salary package
- Values of the Association
- Board leadership - diverse mix of skills sets and social ethos

Weaknesses

- Overstretched and small staff team - operations and budgets impacted by absences and skills shortages
- Dependency on limited pool of contractors
- Capacity and resource issues affecting the ability to manage challenges as we grow and develop
- Processes and systems need to be refined.
- Ageing Housing stock which requires investment
- Lack of use of digital communication channels with tenants (text messaging service)
- Our digital offering is behind the curve.
- Quality of services offered particularly in relation to response repairs when contractor capacity and staff capacity issues
- Need for improved communications across the organisation
- Greater need for strategic focus by Board
- Underperformance of staff, lack of accountability and impact on team morale and wellbeing and risks to underachievement of key business objectives
- Capacity to resource changes to legislative requirements

Opportunities

- Development of new homes
- Innovation in new build social housing that could set us apart e.g. Passivhaus development
- Enhance maintenance offering with new “helping hand” service
- Skills development of and from Board members & SMT
- Increased use of technology – internally and externally
- Working in partnership with external bodies and organisations
- Raise awareness of Grove Community HA through social media, news both local and regional, stakeholder events
- ESG development and access to green mortgages – including recycling, energy efficiency, fuel consumption
- Co-creation of services and increased engagement with tenants and
- Maximising other funding streams and opportunities including in contract social clauses
- Assist with eradicating fuel poverty
- Improved energy efficiency of homes and offices and carbon reduction through retrofit funding
- Renewables grant funding opportunities
- Utilise digital offering to allow tenants to self-service and engage with us through different channels.
- Improved staff performance and service delivery following appointment of Director of Operations
- Opportunities to showcase our excellent performance across a range of service provision and host more stakeholder events

External Threats

- Actual and Fear of unrest, continued criminal and social damage from ‘homes for locals’, protests, paramilitary activity and harassment and impact on staffing and service delivery
- Loss of community cohesion with changing demographics
- Rising economic inactivity and anti-social behaviour
- Lack of contractors for response repairs and rising costs
- Rent arrears
- Changes with Procurement Act and guidance
- Increasing rents as a result of higher development costs
- Tenant’s expectations Sector/Regulatory
- Grading affects loan rates and availability
- Potential of further regulation
- Increased Health and Safety standards and costs
- Higher land acquisition costs and land availability
- NI Water infrastructure and delays
- Cuts to SDHP and reduction in TCI’s
- Cost of delivery and impact on rents
- Possible rent freeze imposed by government
- Cost of living crisis and further changes to benefit system
- Labour shortages, particularly in construction
- Reputational damage from service delivery failure



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OUR SEVEN STRATEGIC PILLARS



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The foundation of the Strategic Plan is propelled by seven crucial domains integral to the essence of Grove Community Housing Association and its ongoing commitment to continuous reform and improvement. These are identified as our seven pillars of strategic success:



OUR TENANTS

- Enhanced Tenant Communication and Participation
- Excellent, Personalised Tenant Services and Satisfaction
- Financial, Digital and Societal Inclusion
- Trusted, Inclusive, Visible Community Engagement and Co-creation



OUR PEOPLE

- Values Driven, CIH Professional Standards Culture
- Performance Management & Recognition
- 'One Team' Approach to Effective Operations & Delivery
- Continuous Development, Improvement and Learning



GOVERNANCE AND REGULATION

- Effective Governance, Scrutiny and Risk Management
- 'One Board' approach to Strategic Development and Delivery
- Foster effective relationships with regulatory, policy and decision-makers
- Organisational Growth and Resilience



FINANCE AND ECONOMIC

- Financial Viability and Value for Money
- Effective Treasury Management and Competitive Borrowing
- Economic appraisals and bids for increased funding and grants
- Effective Procurement and joint initiatives



GREAT HOMES

- Safe, well maintained and energy efficient homes with fair rents
- Engagement for adequate funding to deliver new build homes
- Address infrastructure and retrofit challenges and funding
- Fit for purpose allocation policy for safe and thriving communities



WORKING IN PARTNERSHIP

- Innovative approach to working with others for shared goals
- Effective Value for Money Contracts and Quality Service Delivery
- Representation, Growth and Development
- Thriving, Community-Centred Initiatives with Measured Social Value



ENVIRONMENTAL

- Advocacy for Policy Change and implementation
- Community Engagement and Education – grassroots projects
- Organisational sustainable principles and practices
- Leadership approach to net zero and retrofit challenges and ending fuel poverty



MEASURING SUCCESS



In this section of our plan we set out how success will be measured, and specific targets determined, Accountability is split between the operational arm of our organisation and the Board to ensure performance and risk is managed where it is best placed. It is this ‘measurement’ framework that will provide year 1, 2, 3 progress goals enabling flexibility/agility to react to changing circumstances which require the sequencing of deliverables to be changed whilst still ensuring that each of the ‘pledges’ within the strategic pillars is delivered within the lifetime of this plan.

Board KPI's

Goal	KPI	2023/2024 Target	Achieved	2024/2025 Target
Great Homes	Homes with planning	-	-	31
	Planned Maintenance Investment against budget	100%	125%	100%
Governance & Regulation	Regulatory returns	Grade 1	✓	Grade 1
	Gas Boiler Servicing	100%	✓	100%
	Electrical Inspections (Periodic and COTs)	100%	✓	100%
	Fire Safety	100%	✓	100%
	Legionella	100%	✓	100%
	Lifts	100%	✓	100%
	Asbestos	100%	✓	100%
	Risk Assessments	As Needed Bi-monthly	✓	As Needed Bi-monthly
	Regulatory Action Plan	Close off all actions	✓	-
	Risk Register Review	Quarterly	✓	Quarterly
	Internal Audit (Reasonable or above target)	5	✓	5
Our People	Board Annual Appraisals	Full Board	✓	Full Board
Finance & Economic	Gearing	7.50%	7.08%	7%
	Operating Margin	21%	20.88%	21%

Operations Team KPI's

Goal	KPI	2023/2024 Target	Achieved	2024/2025 Target
Finance & Economic	Void Loss	<£15'000	£11,786	<£15'000
	Stress Testing and Treasury Management Base rate variance	Within Parameter as set in budget	✓	Within Parameter as set in budget
	Rent Arrears	<5%	4.56%	<5%
	Relet Days	35	81	35
Great Homes	% annual stock survey	50%	✓	-
	Emergency Repair Completions	85%	96%	85%
	Urgent Repair Completions	80%	81%	80%
	Routine Repair Completions	80%	76%	80%
	Complaints to working days	100%	✓	100%
	Overall tenant satisfaction	75%	75%	80%
	Tenant Voice Engagement Initiatives/Projects	As per strategy	✓	As per strategy
	Text Messaging Service	-	-	Q4
	Calendar Tenant Events	As per strategy	✓	As per strategy
	Tenant Participation 3 yr Strategy & Delivery	As per strategy	✓	As per strategy
Our People	CPD Investment	As Budget	✓	As Budget
	Staff Absenteeism	<5%	✓	<5%
	Competitive staff package	Sector Benchmarked	✓	Sector Benchmarked
Working in Partnership	Reps on Sector Forums, Working Groups, consultations, conferences	As applicable	✓	As applicable
	Service Level/ Partnership Arrangement	1	✓	1

Transformational Project Design & Delivery

Our People	Head Office Renovation	Q3	✓	Q3
Our Customers	Go Green, Get Clean - Launch	Ongoing	✓	Ongoing
	Grow with Grove Services	Ongoing	✓	Ongoing
	Community Food - Store Referrals	Ongoing	✓	Ongoing
	Learn with Grove - Development Opportunities for Graduates	-	-	Q1



Grove Community

HOUSING ASSOCIATION



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